Practice Article 1

Use of Counselor "Street Talk" to Stimulate Self-Disclosure of Inner-City Youths

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Counseling interviews were conducted with 60 male and female inner-city youths. Half were interviewed in standard English, and half were interviewed in a vernacular commonly used in urban neighborhoods, or "street talk." Self-disclosure of females significantly exceeded that of males under both conditions. Overall, there was a greater amount of self-disclosure when the counselor spoke in the vernacular of the client. A significant interaction showed the least amount of self-disclosure by males but the most self-disclosure by females in the standard English condition.

The rate of emotional disturbances and behavioral problems among inner-city youths is disproportionately high (Battersby & Landsman, 2012; Green, 2009). These individuals are exposed to far more than the ordinary stresses and problems associated with growing up. As documented by Schoenwald (2015), many of them also face problems associated with being

> members of ethnic minorities, low on the ladder of socioeconomic status, economically disadvantaged, in lack of socially acceptable role models, frequently raised in single-parent households, exposed to gangs and peer pressures, menaced by actual and threatened dangers, and presented a short or dim future. (p. 96)

Perceiving themselves as outsiders to mainstream society (Bickel, 2008), inner-city youths, in turn, trust only others from their own social group (Rodriguez & Hernandez, 2013).

Graber (2012) argued these circumstances pose a special problem when counselors try to provide psychological interventions intended for the youths' benefit. As Hernandez (2012) pointed out,

> Professionals who have not shared the experiences of their clients, who do not intimately understand their milieu and way of life, and

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NOTE: This is a fictional article by fictional authors to be used for purposes of research education only. Consuela Eusis-Lang = counselor uses slang; Anita Reveles = Anita Reveals.

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> who do not even speak the same "language" are greatly handicapped when it comes to establishing a trusting relationship. (p. 118)

Aside from personal appearance and attire, one of the first things evident about mental health professionals is their manner of talking. Here, we refer not only to the level of abstraction and the nature and complexity of the concepts being discussed, but to the actual phrases and verbal expressions that are employed. According to McNulty, Spires, and Antonovich (2009), it does not take a prospective client long to "size up" an interviewer and to decide, on the basis of the things that are said and the way in which they are said, that the interviewer, an outsider, is determined not to be trusted.

The judgment about whether someone is "one of us" or "one of them" influences what will happen in the dyadic interaction of therapy. As Kelly (1998) showed in his study with 80 outpatients in a mental health clinic, clients will remain guarded and withholding unless there is some degree of interpersonal trust. Under these circumstances, self-disclosure, a *sine qua non* for successful intervention (Pemberton, 2012), will be minimal.

This study is designed to determine whether the use of "street talk" (i.e., the vernacular used in clients' inner-city neighborhoods) by an interviewer in a counseling situation will lead inner-city youths to self-disclose more than they would if spoken to in standard English. It is predicted that the use of street talk will stimulate positive transference, make clients feel more at ease and more trusting, and (therefore) pave the way for more self-disclosure.

Method

Participants

Participants for this study included 60 youths from inner-city high schools in Newark, NJ. There were 30 male and 30 female teenagers (ages 15–18 years) of diverse ethnic backgrounds. The ethnic distribution included African Americans (48%), Hispanics (32%), Caucasians (10%), and others (Southeast Asians, Middle Easterners, etc., 10%). All youths were born and raised in the United States, and are primarily English speaking, although some are bilingual. Classification by the Hollingshead Index placed all youths at the lower socioeconomic status levels (IV or V). The participants were referred by principals, teachers, and guidance counselors for special help under the auspices of Project COPE. Participants had been singled out for attention for reasons that primarily included disciplinary or truancy problems, a history of aggressive or antisocial behavior, depression, or substance abuse. All agreed to participate in counseling. In addition, permission was obtained from parents or guardians, and the youths assented to participate in a study designed to "improve communication between youths and their adult counselors." Project COPE is headquartered in a downtown office building, and the counseling sessions were conducted in this facility.

The first 15 participants of each sex to enter counseling were interviewed in standard English, whereas the second group of 15 males and 15 females were interviewed in street talk.

Counselors

Two counselors were used for this study. Counselor A is a 42-year-old Caucasian woman with a master's degree in special education and experience in guidance counseling. Counselor B is a 26-year-old, Caucasian woman with a master's degree in guidance counseling. Both are regularly employed in the public schools. Counselor A was asked to conduct all interviews in standard English, whereas Counselor B, who was raised in the Newark area, was instructed to use vernacular English similar to that used in the surrounding inner-city neighborhoods.

Interviews

The study interviews were the initial sessions of an indeterminate series to be held with each participant. The purpose and goals of the sessions were explained initially, and participants were encouraged to discuss how they were getting along in school, at home, and in the neighborhood, and to focus on any special problems that they were currently having and on any future plans. Sessions were open-ended and were not preplanned for content. Rather than being counselor centered, directive, and advice-giving, counselors strongly encouraged participants to talk about themselves. Interviews were 45-min long. Aside from the fact that two counselors were used, the only way that the interviews differed was that half were conducted in standard English and half in street talk.

Independent Variable Conditions

Chisholm and Grady's (2014) standards for street talk were adopted for this study. The standards include the frequency of use of colloquialisms, slang, local pronunciations and syntax, vulgarisms and obscenities, interjections (e.g., "like," "bro," "you know"), and assorted nonverbal gestures that accompany, accentuate, and highlight vocal expressions. Counselor B, who was not unfamiliar with street talk, was nevertheless given orientation and instruction in its use. A 2-hr practice session was held, featuring recording and instructional feedback. Not until she was judged to have met the standards was she permitted to proceed with actual study participants. The principal investigator used Chisholm and Grady's checklist to determine proficiency.

As a manipulation check, 5-min time samples of the counselor's talk from early, middle, and late portions of recordings of actual experimental interviews were subjected to the same checklist appraisal. The speech of Counselor A, who was to speak standard English, was similarly checked to make sure that this condition was correctly applied.

Dependent Variable Criterion

The dependent variable, self-disclosure, was rated by Hannigan's (2002) method. This method asks raters to focus on 10 aspects of speech pattern, including use of first-person pronouns and self-referential themes, and it involves talk about one's feelings, attitudes, hopes, wishes, fears, relationships, and personal experiences. Self-disclosure during the interview was rated on a 4-point Likert scale (4 = *a great deal*, 3 = *considerable*, 2 = *a little*, and 1 = *not at all*).

Interviews were video recorded and were rated by two research assistants. As described previously, early, middle, and late time-sample segments were rated. When the two raters disagreed on a rating, they reviewed the tape segment together and reevaluated the rating until they reached agreement. If they could not reach agreement, the decision was made by the principal investigator.

The three segment ratings were averaged for each of the 10 items, and then the average scores for each were summed. This provided a score for each participant with a possible range of 10 to 40.

Results

As can be seen in Table 1, the self-disclosure score for the females ($M = 22.57$) across the two conditions exceeds that for the males ($M = 17.13$), and the sex variable is significant ($F(1, 56) = 9.67$, $p = .003$), as shown in Table 2. As predicted, self-disclosure to

Table 1
Means and Standard Deviations of Self-Disclosure

	Street talk			Standard English			
Sex	*M*	*SD*	*n*	*M*	*SD*	*n*	Total
Boys	20.4	3.80	15	13.87	4.24	15	17.13
Girls	22.33	11.37	15	22.80	5.53	15	22.57
Total	21.37			18.33			

Table 2
Analysis of Variance of Self-Disclosure by Type of Talk and Sex Group

Source	Sum of squares	*df*	Mean square	*F*
Sex	442.817	1	442.817	9.67***
Type of talk	138.017	1	138.017	3.01*
Sex × talk	183.750	1	183.750	4.01**
Error	2,565.067	56	45.805	
Total	3,329.651	59		

*p = .088, ** p = .05, *** p = .003

street talk (M = 21.37) is greater than to standard English (M = 18.33). The F-test for this comparison shows a strong trend in support of the hypothesis ($F(1, 56) = 3.01$, p = .088). There is a significant Sex × Type of Talk interaction ($F(1, 56) = 4.01$, p = .05). This interaction is portrayed in Figure 1. The least amount of self-disclosure is shown by males in interviews that were conducted in standard English (M = 13.87), and the most by females in the standard English condition (M = 22.80).

Discussion

As the data demonstrates, there is a strong trend to support the proposition that the use of street talk by counselors leads to increased self-disclosure, at least in the initial interview with male inner-city youths. The first interview is critical in determining the future path of the intervention, particularly for disaffected youths who are not strongly committed to the idea of counseling in the first place. If resistance to counseling is reinforced instead of diminished during the initial interview, the outlook for future sessions is less optimistic.

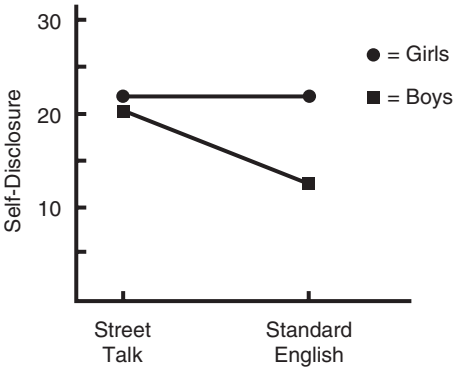


Figure 1. Sex × Type of Talk interaction.

The use of street talk by counselors who are faced with this type of client has proven to be a promising way of reducing initial resistance, increasing comfort, decreasing negative attitudes toward the counselor, and thereby providing an atmosphere that facilitates self-disclosure.

It is interesting to note that the data reveal a significant effect of the clients' sex. Females displayed significantly more self-disclosure than did males. Further, it made no difference for females whether they were interviewed in street talk or standard English.

This sex difference in self-disclosure is shown in related contexts. Females, in general, are known to be more expressive of feelings (Elkin, 1999), more verbally communicative (Schwartz & Sopwith, 2011), quicker to relate interpersonally (Feldman, Crouch, & Rodriguez, 2014), and more apt to seek out psychotherapy (Feodor, 2009). The finding that they self-disclose more readily is consistent with all of these prior findings.

This study has implications for counseling and therapy with various other groups. It shows that it is important to "talk the talk" of the group with which a client is principally identified. Counselors and psychotherapists are advised to speak using the vernacular of the client to maximize the chances of early self-disclosure.

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